

THE MONEY HEALING SERIES

Money and Mental Health

*The Hidden Link Between Your Finances
and Your Wellbeing*

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Results mentioned are illustrative only. Individual circumstances vary significantly. The publisher assumes no liability for actions taken based on information in this book.

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The Financial Stress Spiral

Financial stress doesn't just feel bad. It measurably impairs the cognitive functions you need to fix it.

What Stress Does to Financial Decisions

The landmark research by Sendhil Mullainathan and Eldar Shafir, published in their book *Scarcity*, demonstrated something that feels intuitive once you hear it but has profound implications: financial stress consumes cognitive bandwidth. When your mind is preoccupied with how to pay a bill, that preoccupation actively reduces your IQ-equivalent performance on other tasks.

This creates a trap. Financial stress degrades your decision-making precisely when good decisions are most important. The person who most needs to think clearly about money is the person least equipped to do so.

Understanding this is not an excuse — it's a design principle. Systems that work even under stress are more valuable than perfect plans that require your best self.

"Financial stress is not a character failure. It's a cognitive tax."

Depression, Anxiety, and the Bank Account

*Mental health and financial health move together.
Treating them separately is inefficient.*

When Mental Health Drives Financial Behavior

Depression frequently manifests financially as avoidance: not opening mail, not checking accounts, not making calls, letting bills slide not from negligence but from an inability to generate the energy or hope required to act.

Anxiety frequently manifests as hypervigilance or paralysis: obsessive checking of accounts, inability to spend even on necessities, or conversely, compulsive spending as a tension-relief mechanism.

ADHD — covered more fully in another series — affects financial behavior through impulsivity, difficulty with future planning, and executive function challenges that make budgeting mechanically harder.

None of these are moral failures. All of them have practical workarounds.

*"Your mental health is a financial variable.
Account for it."*

Automating Around Your Worst Days

Build your financial systems for your Tuesday-at-10pm self, not your best Saturday morning self.

The Power of Automation

Automatic transfers, automatic savings, automatic bill payments — these are not just conveniences. For people with mental health challenges, they are essential infrastructure.

Every decision you automate is a decision your depressed or anxious self cannot sabotage. The money moves before you can talk yourself out of it, spend it on something else, or simply forget.

Set up: automatic transfer to savings on payday, automatic minimum payments on all debt (to prevent late fees even during hard months), automatic contributions to retirement accounts. Then build from there.

"Automation is compassion for your future self."

Financial Therapy — What It Is and When to Seek It

*Therapy for money feels indulgent to many people.
The cost of not getting it is usually much higher.*

The Financial Therapist's Role

Financial therapy sits at the intersection of emotional counseling and financial planning. A financial therapist helps you understand the emotional roots of your financial behaviors — not just what to do with money, but why you do what you already do.

It is different from a financial planner, who focuses on strategy and products. And it's different from a general therapist, who may not have specific training in money psychology.

The Financial Therapy Association (financialtherapy.org) maintains a directory. Many therapists offer sliding scale fees. Some financial coaches incorporate therapeutic techniques without charging therapy rates.

*"Understanding the why changes what you do
with the what."*

Finding Stability in Uncertainty

Financial certainty is rare. Financial resilience is learnable.

The Minimum Viable Financial Safety Net

In a period of mental health challenge, the goal isn't optimization. It's stability. Stability means: housing is covered, utilities are on, food is available, debt isn't actively growing, something small is being saved.

This is enough. When you're in a hard season, maintaining stability is a genuine achievement — not a consolation prize.

The more ambitious goals exist. They can wait. Stability first, then growth.

"Stability is not the floor. It's the foundation."

Building a Financial Safety Team

Money problems that feel private are often better solved with help.

Who Should Be on Your Team

Nonprofit credit counselors (NFCC members) offer free financial counseling and debt management plans. They are not trying to sell you anything.

Community organizations, credit unions, and many employers offer free financial wellness programs that most people never access.

A trusted friend or family member who will look at your finances with you — not to judge but to witness — can make the invisible visible in ways that solo review cannot.

You don't have to figure this out alone. That belief is part of what keeps the spiral spinning.

"Financial health is a team sport masquerading as a solo one."
